Twelve Everyday Things to Notice and Write Down While Mom Is Managing at Home

What to pay attention to on an ordinary visit, and how to note it, with no diagnosing and no verdicts.

You visit Mom and something seems a little different. You can't quite say what. This guide names twelve everyday things worth noticing and, for each, what to write down.

Notice and record. Don't interpret. What a change means is a question for her doctor, her pharmacist or another professional who knows her, and dated notes are what make that conversation useful. Where an item carries a number, the area comes from the public source listed at the end. The wording about what to write down is ours. This is a list of things to notice. It isn't a list of problems.

Everyday activities

1 Bathing, dressing and personal care [1]

NOTICE Whether she manages these on her own, takes longer than she used to, or has changed how she does them.

WRITE DOWN What she does on her own and where she gets a hand, with today's date.

2 Meals and groceries [1]

NOTICE Who shops, who cooks, what's in the fridge, and whether meals have become simpler.

WRITE DOWN A typical day's meals, and who made them.

3 Housework [1]

NOTICE The jobs she still does herself, the ones someone else has taken on, and the ones that are waiting.

WRITE DOWN Who does which jobs now, and roughly when that started.

4 Bills, mail and paperwork [1]

NOTICE Who opens the mail and pays the bills, whether envelopes are piling up, and any unfamiliar callers or letters she mentions.

WRITE DOWN Who handles what, as plain facts. Leave what it means alone.

Getting around

5 Walking and getting up from a chair [2]

NOTICE Whether she holds onto walls, furniture or someone's arm when she walks, and how she gets up from a chair.

WRITE DOWN What you saw, where, and the date.

6 Falls and near-falls [2]

NOTICE A fall, a stumble, a grab for the counter, and anything she says about feeling dizzy or unsteady.

WRITE DOWN The date, the place and what she was doing. Ask her whether she is concerned about falling, and note her answer.

7 Driving and getting places

NOTICE Where she drives and when, the trips she has started to pass up, and who gives her rides.

WRITE DOWN The trips she makes herself and the rides she gets. Whether she should be driving isn't a family verdict; a concern goes to her doctor.

Health, medications and memory

8 Medications [2]

NOTICE Who fills the pill organizer, whether she has trouble remembering to take them, and anything she says about side effects.

WRITE DOWN What you saw and what she told you. Change nothing; questions go to her doctor and her pharmacist.

9 Health and appointments

NOTICE Her diagnoses and treatments as you understand them, the appointments coming up, and who goes with her.

WRITE DOWN What you know, what you're unsure of, and the questions you'd like asked at the next visit.

10 Memory [3]

NOTICE A repeated question, a missed appointment, trouble with a familiar device or a familiar route.

WRITE DOWN What happened, when, and how often. Not what it means.

Home and help

11 Lights, rails and grab bars [2]

NOTICE The lighting, whether the stairs have secure rails, and whether the bathroom has grab bars.

WRITE DOWN What is there and what isn't. The Administration for Community Living names an occupational therapist as the professional to consult about the home.

12 Who helps now [4]

NOTICE Everyone who does anything for her: family, friends, neighbors, any paid help. And what has changed over the past year.

WRITE DOWN Who helps, with what, how often, and since when.

When a note isn't enough

If Mom says she is concerned about falling, dizziness or her balance, the Administration for Community Living's advice is that she discuss it with her health care provider. If she is having a hard time keeping track of her medicines, its advice is to take that to her doctor and her pharmacist. If she is worried about her memory, MedlinePlus says to see a health care provider. Anything new and sudden is a call to her doctor, not a note for later, and an emergency is a call to emergency services.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what any of these mean, whether Mom is safe at home or safe to drive, or what kind of care she may need. It says nothing about eligibility for any program, and it isn't medical, legal, financial or tax advice. The people who know her health do the judging, and they do it better with your notes in front of them.

Ready for the next step?

You know what to pay attention to, and you've started a dated page of notes. The care interview goes through the same areas with you one at a time, so nothing important is overlooked, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), What is Long-Term Care?
2. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Avoiding a Fall
3. MedlinePlus (National Library of Medicine), Memory | MedlinePlus
4. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Where Can You Receive Care?